Changes in Rajya Sabha Elections: In 2003, the following two changes were introduced with respect to elections to the Rajya Sabha[12]:

1. Domicile or residency requirement of a candidate contesting an election to the Rajya Sabha was removed. Prior to this, a candidate had to be an elector in the state from where he/she was to be elected. Now, it would be sufficient if he/she is an elector in any parliamentary constituency in the country.

2. Introducing open ballot system, instead of secret ballot system, for elections to the Rajya Sabha. This was done to curb cross-voting and to wipe out the role of money power during Rajya Sabha elections. Under the new system, an elector belonging to a political party has to show the ballot paper after marking his/her vote to a nominated agent of that political party.

Exemption of Travelling Expenditure As per a provision of 2003[13], the travelling expenditure incurred by the campaigning leaders of a political party shall be exempted from being included in the election expenses of the candidate.

Free Supply of Electoral Rolls, etc. According to a 2003 provision[14], the Government should supply, free of cost, the copies of the electoral rolls and other prescribed material to the candidates of recognised political parties for the Lok Sabha and Assembly elections. Further, the Election Commission should supply specified items to the voters in the constituencies concerned or to the candidates set up by the recognised political parties.

Parties Entitled to Accept Contribution In 2003[15], the political parties were entitled to accept any amount of contribution from any person or company other than a government company. They have to report any contribution in excess of ₹20,000 to the Election Commission for making any claim to any income tax relief. Besides, the companies would get income tax exemption on the amount contributed.

Allocation of Time on Electronic Media Under a 2003 provision[16], the Election Commission should allocate equitable sharing of time on the cable television network and other electronic media during elections to display or propagate any matter or to address public. This allocation would be decided on the basis of the past performance of a recognised political party.

Introduction of Braille Signage Features in EVMs The Commission received representations from the various associations of visually impaired persons for introduction of Braille signage features in the EVMs to facilitate the visually impaired voters to cast their votes without the help of attendant. The Commission considered the proposal in detail and tried the Braille signage feature in the EVMs during the bye-election to the Asifnagar Assembly Constituency of Andhra Pradesh held in 2004. In 2008, it was tried in all the assembly constituencies of NCT of Delhi during Assembly elections.

The Commission introduced similar Braille signage features on the Electronic Voting Machines during the General Elections to the Fifteenth Lok Sabha (2009) and simultaneous Assembly elections in some States.[17]

ELECTORAL REFORMS SINCE 2010

Restrictions Imposed on Exit Polls According to a 2009 provision[18], conducting exit polls and publishing results of exist polls would be prohibited during the election to Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies. Thus, no person shall conduct any exit poll and publish or publicise by means of the print or